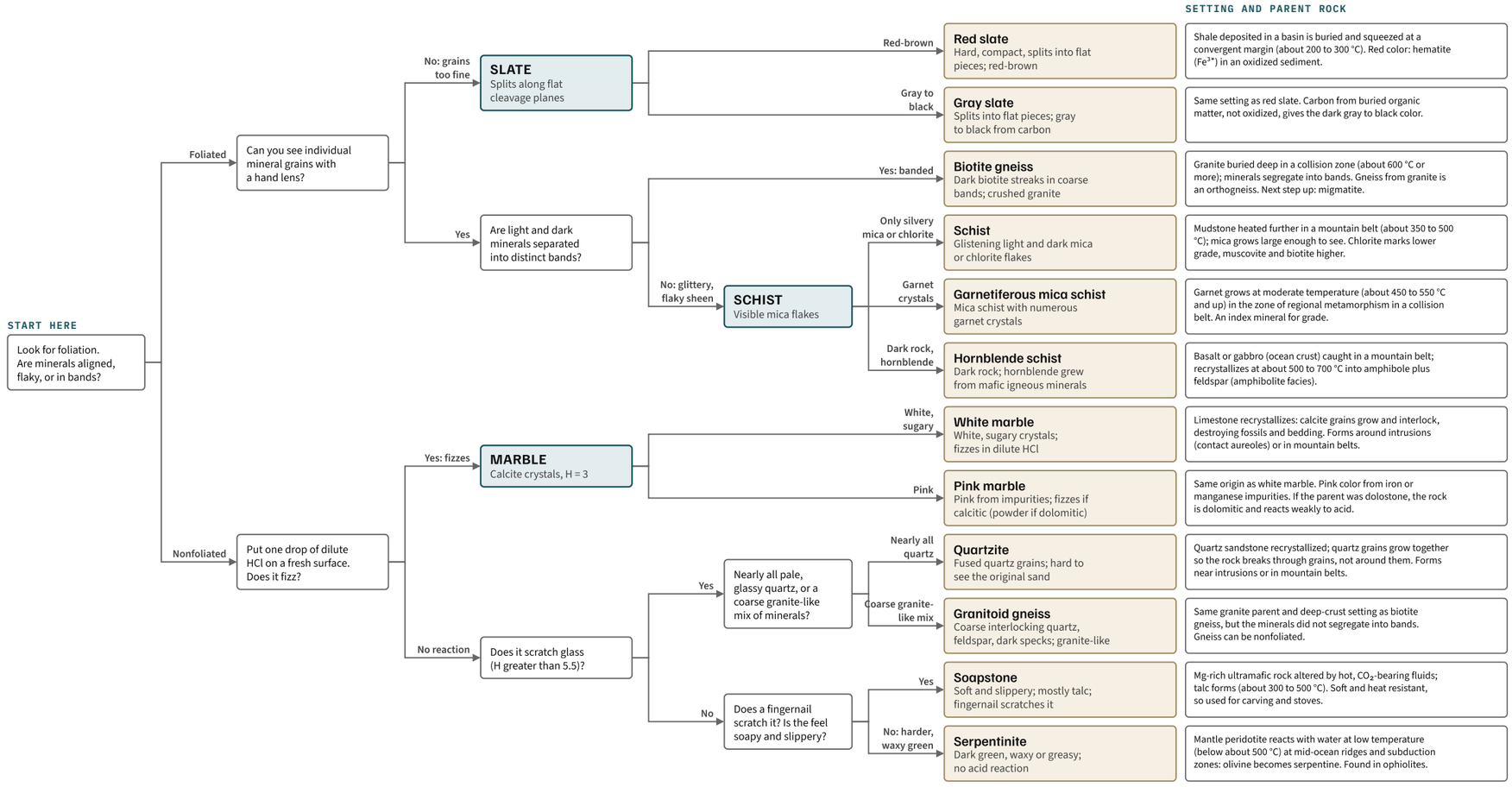
Metamorphic Rock Identification Key

Ward's Metamorphic Rock Collection 45 E 3120. Start at the left box and follow the answers to your specimen.



Foliated rocks and metamorphic grade

Slate, phyllite, schist and gneiss form a sequence of increasing temperature and pressure. Grains coarsen and minerals separate into bands. Phyllite is not in this set: grains are still too fine to see, but it has a satiny sheen and wavy surfaces.

Hardness benchmarks (Mohs)

Fingernail 2.5 · copper coin about 3.5 · steel nail and glass about 5.5 · quartz 7.
Soapstone (talc) is 1. Marble (calcite) is 3. Quartzite is 7.

Acid test and parent rocks

One drop of dilute HCl, goggles on. Calcite marble fizzes; dolomitic marble needs scratched powder first.
Parent rock: slate and schist from shale, gneiss from granite, marble from limestone, quartzite from sandstone.